



Green sea turtle

Chelonia mydas

elongated
front limbs
modified
into flippers



The world's second largest turtle (after the leatherback), the green sea turtle is mostly solitary, swimming from one feeding area to another. Adult sea turtles graze inshore on marine plants using their toothless, horny, sharp-edged beaks, which have serrations on the lower jaw. When young, they are partly carnivorous, eating jellyfish, crustaceans, worms, and sponges.

Green sea turtles have a streamlined, teardrop-shaped carapace (upper shell). The common name comes from the layer of green fat between their shell and organs. The turtles swim using a flap-twist motion of the front flippers, with the shorter rear flippers acting as rudders. Their cruising speed is 1–2 mph (2–3 km/h)—in mid-migration they can cover 50 miles (80 km) daily—but can reach 20 mph (30 km/h) if threatened. Sea turtles can hold their breath for more than five hours when resting

underwater, although they surface every three to five minutes when feeding and traveling, and often sleep under a ledge or on the sea floor.

Distinct populations

Two green sea turtle populations occur in the Pacific and Atlantic oceans. Individuals roam widely, some covering more than 5,000 miles (8,000 km) yearly between their traditional feeding and mating-nesting areas. When mature, they return to their natal (hatching) beach. Many males arrive every year, females every two to three years. Hundreds gather up to 1 mile (2 km) offshore to mate. The female crawls onto the sandy beach at night, digs a hole with her flippers, deposits 100–200 eggs, fills the pit, and returns to sea. Depending on the temperature, hatching occurs 45–70 days later.

- ↔ 3–4 ft (1–1.2 m)
- ⚖ 143–286 lb (65–130 kg)
- ⊗ Endangered
- 🌿 Seagrass, seaweed
- 🏠 



Temperate and tropical
waters worldwide